Q+A

"90 IS JUST A NUMBER"

Olympic javelin gold medallist **Neeraj Chopra** on his *mithai* cravings, goals for the 2023 season and cracking that elusive 90-metre mark

Q. Six of your career-best throws came in 2022. What did you get right this year?
During training, I focused on certain aspects of my technique, like the direction in which I needed to release the javelin. Besides, there's a change in my mentality, and a greater belief in myself after the Olympics. Unlike in the past, now I feel I am performing at the level of world-class athletes. It has worked wonders.

Q. What has the off season been like?
I was in Switzerland with my family. I also travelled to Tokyo for a programme, where I refreshed my memories of the Olympic gold. When I'm home, there is less control over what I am eating, like I really dig into Indian *mithai*. So, once training starts, it's difficult for the first couple of weeks. But then I get into the training mindset.

Q. The World Championships and Asian Games are within a month of each other in 2023. What are your goals for next season?
The aim is to peak in time for the two events. The Diamond League, Asian Championships, World Championships and the Asian Games are the main competitions. I also want to ensure that I keep up the training momentum for the 2024 Paris Olympics.

Q. The 90-metre mark is still elusive...
It's just a number, honestly, and I know I'm almost there. I got really close in Stockholm [Diamond League] with 89.94 metres. Whenever that throw is meant to happen, it'll happen. There's no pressure on that count.

Q. You starred in the promo for the Marvel movie, *Black Panther: Wakanda Forever*. If you could have a superpower, what would it be?
The ability to travel really fast. They say our universe is infinite, I would like to go see how big it is, how far a billion light years really is.

with Shail Desai

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH
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